10 OPENING TRAPS

THE CHEAT SHEET + QUIZ

Spot them. Beat them.
Then test yourself.

Made for your phone. Swipe through.



BEFORE EVERY MOVE

THE 3-SECOND CHECK.

1 **THEIR CHECKS**
Can they give check next move?

2 **THEIR CAPTURES**
What can they take? Is anything of mine loose?

3 **THEIR THREATS**
What are their pieces aiming at?

Each trap in this kit punishes a move played without this check.

HOW TO USE THIS KIT

Read one trap per page. Then try the quiz at the back. Tap the gold buttons to see a trap move on the board.

TRAP 01 / 10

Scholar's Mate

KING'S PAWN OPENING · WHITE SETS IT

Queen and bishop gang up on f7. Mate in four moves, unless you defend first.



THE BLUNDER

3...Nf6??



CHECKMATE

4.Qxf7#

IN PLAIN WORDS

White points the queen and a bishop at one weak square next to Black's king. If Black doesn't defend it, the queen takes it and it's checkmate in four moves. Block the queen first, then chase it away.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- After Qh5, defend first: block with g6 or protect f7 with Qe7.
- Once f7 is safe, develop your knights and make the white queen run.
- An early queen is a target, not a danger, as long as you defend first.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 02 / 10

Légal's Mate

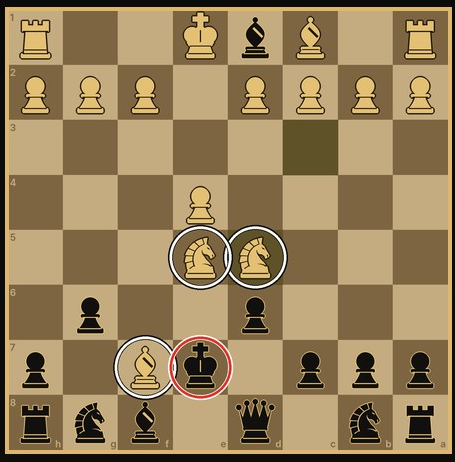
PHILIDOR DEFENSE · WHITE SETS IT

White gives away the queen and mates in two. Almost 300 years old, and it still works.



THE BLUNDER

5...Bxd1??



CHECKMATE

7.Nd5#

IN PLAIN WORDS

White seems to give away the queen for free. If Black grabs it, three small pieces trap the black king and it's checkmate two moves later. Don't take the queen: take the knight instead. You lose a pawn, not the game.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't grab the queen. Take the knight with 5...dxe5 instead.
- You lose a pawn, not the game. A free queen is never free when your king is in danger.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 03 / 10

Fried Liver Attack

ITALIAN GAME · WHITE SETS IT

White gives up a knight on f7 and drags Black's king into the middle of the board.



THE MISTAKE

5...Nxd5?



THE ATTACK

8.Nc3

IN PLAIN WORDS

White sacrifices a knight to pull Black's king out of its safe spot. The king ends up in the middle of the board, where every white piece can attack it. Avoid it: don't take back in the center, attack the bishop with your knight instead.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't take back on d5 with the knight. Play 5...Na5! and attack the bishop.
- A king in the center is a target. Keep it behind its pawns.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 04 / 10

Fishing Pole Trap

RUY LOPEZ · BLACK SETS IT

Black leaves a knight hanging on g4. Take it, and the h-file opens straight onto your king.



FIRST MISTAKE

5.h3?



CHECKMATE

13...Qh1#

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black leaves a knight hanging right next to White's king. If White takes it, a whole column opens up towards the king, and Black's queen and rook give checkmate in the corner. Kicking the knight away is fine. Taking it is not.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't push the h-pawn when the knight lands on g4. h3 is the first mistake.
- Your king hides behind f2, g2 and h2. Keep them home and keep developing.
- If the knight is left hanging after ...h5, don't take it. The open h-file is worth more than a knight.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 05 / 10

Blackburne Shilling Gambit

ITALIAN GAME · BLACK SETS IT

Black hangs a pawn on purpose. Grab it, get greedy, and it's mate on move seven.



THE GREED

4.Nxe5?



CHECKMATE

7...Nf3#

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black leaves a pawn hanging on purpose. If White grabs it and then goes for even more, Black's queen crashes in and a knight gives checkmate. Don't take the pawn: castle, or take Black's knight.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't take on e5. Castle, or take the knight on d4.
- If you did take and the queen comes to g5, don't grab more: castle (your king then covers g2) and give the knight back.
- A free pawn that opens lines to your king is not free.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 06 / 10

Stafford Gambit

PETROV DEFENSE · BLACK SETS IT

Black gives away the queen on purpose. Take it, and it's mate in two.



THE MISTAKE

6.Bg5??



CHECKMATE

8...Bg4#

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black gives away the queen on purpose. If White takes it, Black's bishops and knight checkmate White's king two moves later. Before you grab a queen, check every check your opponent has.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't play Bg5. Develop with Be2 and castle.
- Before you grab a queen, check every check.
- f2 is weak in the opening. Watch out for bishops aiming at it.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 07 / 10

Englund Gambit

ENGLUND GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

Black gives a pawn on move one. Chase the queen the wrong way and it's mate on your back rank.



THE BLUNDER

6.Bc3??



CHECKMATE

8...Qc1#

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black throws away a pawn on move one and brings the queen out early. If White chases the queen the wrong way, the row behind White's king is left empty, and the queen gives checkmate there. Develop your knight instead and keep that row covered.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- After the queen takes b2, play Nc3, not Bc3.
- Keep your back rank covered when the enemy queen is close to it.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 08 / 10

Elephant Trap

QUEEN'S GAMBIT DECLINED · BLACK SETS IT

The d5 pawn looks free. Grab it and you lose a whole piece.



THE GREED

6.Nxd5??



PIECE UP

9...Kxd8

IN PLAIN WORDS

A pawn looks free because the knight defending it seems stuck. It isn't. If White grabs the pawn, Black gives the queen, wins it straight back with check and ends up a whole piece ahead. Count the pieces before you grab.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- A pinned knight can still move if it wins something bigger. Check that first.
- Don't take on d5 here. Just develop with e3.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 09 / 10

Lasker Trap

ALBIN COUNTER-GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

A pawn marches all the way and turns into a knight, with check.



THE MISTAKE

4.e3?



UNDERPROMOTION

7...fxg1=N+!

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black pushes a pawn deep into White's position. If White grabs a bishop, that pawn keeps capturing, reaches the last row and turns into a knight with check. White's position falls apart. Bring your knight out early instead.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Play 4.Nf3 instead of e3.
- When an enemy pawn is that close to your king, deal with the pawn before you grab anything.

Step through it on the board →

TRAP 10 / 10

Siberian Trap

SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

Queen and knight aim at h2. Kick the knight and it's mate in two.



THE BLUNDER

9.h3??



CHECKMATE

10...Qh2#

IN PLAIN WORDS

Black's queen and knight both aim at the square next to White's king. If White kicks the knight and then takes the bait, the only defender of that square disappears and the queen gives checkmate. Don't kick the knight: chase the queen away instead.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't play h3. Play Nb5 and chase the queen away from h2.
- When two pieces aim at the square next to your king, keep its defender in place.

Step through it on the board →

QUIZ 1 / 2

WHAT DO YOU PLAY?

You are the one to move. Answers on the last pages.



Q1 · Black to move



Q2 · Black to move



Q3 · Black to move



Q4 · White to move

Ruy Lopez



Q5 · White to move

Italian Game

Hint: check every check, capture and threat before you move.

QUIZ 2 / 2

WHAT DO YOU PLAY?

You are the one to move. Answers on the last pages.



Q6 · White to move



Q7 · White to move



Q8 · White to move



Q9 · White to move

Albin Counter-Gambit



Q10 · White to move

Smith-Morra Gambit

Hint: check every check, capture and threat before you move.

ANSWERS

HOW DID YOU DO?

Q1 **Scholar's Mate**
After Qh5, defend first: block with g6 or protect f7 with Qe7.

Q2 **Légal's Mate**
Don't grab the queen. Take the knight with 5...dxe5 instead.

Q3 **Fried Liver Attack**
Don't take back on d5 with the knight. Play 5...Na5! and attack the bishop.

Q4 **Fishing Pole Trap**
Don't push the h-pawn when the knight lands on g4. h3 is the first mistake.

Q5 **Blackburne Shilling Gambit**
Don't take on e5. Castle, or take the knight on d4.

Q6 **Stafford Gambit**
Don't play Bg5. Develop with Be2 and castle.

Q7 **Englund Gambit**
After the queen takes b2, play Nc3, not Bc3.

Q8 **Elephant Trap**
A pinned knight can still move if it wins something bigger. Check that first.

Q9 **Lasker Trap**
Play 4.Nf3 instead of e3.

Q10 **Siberian Trap**
Don't play h3. Play Nb5 and chase the queen away from h2.

WANT TO SEE THEM MOVE?

Watch all ten traps in one video, with the fix for each.

Watch: 10 Opening Traps →

The trap library →

Analyze your own games →

One new chess lesson a day on YouTube, Instagram and TikTok: @ThroiyChess

